

Chapter 3

Imagining and Transforming Higher Education. Knowledge Production in the New Geopolitics of Knowledge



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3.1 Introduction

The idea that we live in global knowledge societies and knowledge-based economies or that present-day productive systems constitute an industry 4.0 have gained currency as descriptions of contemporary society that are said to bear direct and indirect consequences for political, economic, and social orders. In this context, higher education – in terms of its missions of innovation, research and education – has been placed center stage in contemporary discussions about the future of modern societies. In globalized discourses on the theme, *innovation* is enthusiastically embraced as the panacea for all sorts of societal and economic issues of our times; *research* is equally deemed to play a decisive role in solving current problems and in heralding a bright future with more wealth and more welfare for all citizens; *education* is conferred the task to producing individuals equipped with both skills and competences considered key to innovation but also displaying the attitudes and dispositions that will secure continuous innovation and economic growth.

High-level policy interest parallels this enthusiasm placing knowledge and knowledge generation activities centerpiece in imaginations of the future, for instance, under the EU's strategies of creating the most competitive global knowledge-economy and becoming an Innovation Union, in national innovation policies of competing nation-states, or in the business strategies of (new) market participants. In this context, higher education institutions as main spaces of

This chapter is dedicated to S. Karin Amos.

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knowledge production have become an *idée fixe*, a constant *topos* in the imaginations of knowledge-intensive capitalism and of how they are to contribute to innovation and economic growth. Higher education (HE) is deemed central to the realization of this vision and invoked as the prime *locus* of production both of (proprietary) knowledge (such as patents, innovations of all kinds, etc.), of innovative learning environments, and not least of human capital and associated subjectivities that will drive innovation.

The chapter argues that higher education, in this setting, is part of a *New geopolitics of knowledge* that refers to the integration of higher education in the imaginations and calculations of different actors aiming at asserting and/or improving their positions in the global knowledge-based economy. This integration, the chapter argues, not only prompts a (re-)imagination of the future of HE in terms of serving knowledge-intensive capitalism, but also reshapes and transforms HE missions and infrastructures. The chapter starts by, *first*, introducing a geopolitical perspective that, it is argued, can help us understand and deliberate on the implications of current developments shaping higher education. Here the theme of geopolitics is unfolded and two different strands of the debate about a (new) geopolitics of knowledge discussed that offer a conceptual perspective for assessing the relevance and implications of current developments. *Second*, in taking a global perspective, the chapter presents two distinct sets of contexts that shape contemporary transformations in higher education. To start with, the integration of higher education in global regionalism projects is examined in terms of the relevance of these policy contexts as a background for developments in the field; in what follows, we look into the emerging Global Education Industry (GEI) that also serves as an influential shaper of higher education transformations. In a *third* section, the chapter discusses examples of how current transformations in higher education can be better grasped by adopting a geopolitical lens. The section considers the creation of international education hubs by states aspiring to improve their position in global economic circuits; and it discusses the placelessness of the (imagined) future of higher education by examining a current project that aims at disrupting the future of higher education: the Minerva Project.

The following section introduces and discusses geopolitics as a lens to examine higher education transformations, before two sets of contexts transforming higher education are discussed in more detail.

3.2 A New Geopolitics of Knowledge?

Geopolitics is defined as representing “the struggle over hegemony in places and spaces.” (Petersen & Wehrmann, 2015: no page) Geopolitics refers to the influence of factors such as (physical, human) geography, economics and demography/population on politics, and in particular the foreign policies, of a state (OED, 2020). It focuses both on political power and geographic space. The term has a long and controversial history due to its association with colonial and imperial ideologies.

The orthodox view of geopolitics served as justification for the aggressive Nazi-German expansionism that led to the great catastrophe of the Second World War, thus almost disappearing from the political vocabularies of the post-war era, until it was repopularized by US policy advisors and in particular by Samuel P. Huntington's controversial book *'Clash of Civilizations'* (1996).

In its classical usage in international political relations, geopolitics refers to strategic aims of the state, focusing primarily on territorial expansion and control over natural resources and populations in pursuing state's goals. Only more recently have scholars expanded it to include political and cultural production and take into consideration actors beyond the state (Petersen & Wehrmann, 2015; see also Kuus, 2017).

Drawing from recent intellectual developments in human geography and political geography, scholars working from the perspective of critical geopolitics (see Kuus, 2017) examine the geographical assumptions and discursive constructions that shape world politics (Agnew, 2003, see also 1999). They argue that "spatiality is not confined to territoriality" and that we need to pay attention to the politics of spatializing "international politics and represent[ing] it as a 'world' characterized by particular types of places" (Kuus, 2017: 2). In its attempt to illuminate and explain these practices, critical geopolitics expanded the classical notion of geopolitics to encompass efforts by „dominant states and their ruling social strata to master space – to control territories and/or the interactional flows through which modern terrestrial spaces are produced.“ (Agnew and Corbridge, quoted in Moisiso, 2018: 3) This conceptualization adds relational and discursive-semiotic aspects to the territorial and is concerned with how geopolitical order is constructed and stabilized not only by means of territorial control, but also through discourses and meaning-making practices. It also problematizes statist assumptions by incorporating actors other than states in the study of geopolitical phenomena. In short, geopolitics then may be taken to denote territorial, relational, and discursive aspects of political imaginaries, in which the world has become a global network of cities, regions, hubs or (free) economic zones that drive knowledge-intensive capitalist accumulation in the twenty-first century (see: Moisiso, 2018).

Indeed, while current public discourse and policy rhetoric refers to geopolitics as concerned less with territorial competition, national interests and security – even though these concerns still clearly underlie strategic policy planning. To be sure, while inter-state competition over territories and ‚spheres of influence‘ are constantly downplayed and relegated to a past before the age of globalization and neo-liberal politics, classical notions of geopolitics still can be found in contemporary political debates – for instance, after the Russian annexation of Crimea, politicians and media interpreted this as an act of old-fashioned geopolitical strategy belonging to the twentieth century (see: Moisiso, 2018). Recent developments such as the Brexit or the trade wars between the USA and China may also illustrate the geopolitics of power. While political and scholarly debates alike oftentimes characterize geopolitics in terms of the movement from an old-fashioned territorial power play condition of the industrial society, to one of relational and networked “‘hub and flow imaginaries’” (Moisiso, 2018: 7) of the knowledge society, this chapter argues that these two notions are both co-constitutive of current developments and that

power play politics is still at work in these developments. One example of this may be seen in the recently signed Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP) among the ten members of the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), plus China, Japan, South Korea, Australia and New Zealand. While discourses of the global connectivity of open, unhindered flows in international free-trade figure prominently in justifications of the agreement, both China's political strategy to trump the alternative Trans-Pacific Partnership (TPP, which excluded China) and the global economic regionalism policies of the signatory states were key to RCEP's success (see also ASEAN, 2020).

A second strand of the discussion about a geopolitics of knowledge dates from the 1990s and early 2000s and developed amidst critical and postcolonial debates of the role of knowledge in world order (Dussel, 1993; Mignolo, 2002, 2003). Geopolitics of knowledge refers here both to the role of philosophical projects and epistemological paradigms in stabilizing a (Western, imperial) social and political order of the world – hinting thus at the role of science/knowledge in (orthodox) geopolitical projects. More recently, the debate has been further elaborated to include conceptual (imaginings) and practical (designs) of social liberation and construction of a pluriverse (Escobar, 2018; Reiter, 2019).

Starting in the early-1990s several scholars referred to 'geopolitics of knowledge' to criticize what some characterized as a 'Eurocentric critique of modernity'. For instance, Enrique Dussel (1993) was one of the most voiced critics of postmodernity. For him a postmodern critique of modernity was necessary and important, but not enough. In his book *Postmodernidad y Transmodernidad* (1999) he developed a powerful critique of what he and later other scholars termed 'the geopolitics of knowledge'. They saw it as "organized around the diversification, through history, of the colonial and the imperial differences." (Mignolo, 2002: 59) Colonial and imperial difference denotes the absolute difference between the colonizer and the colonized. For these scholars, colonization was not only related to the planetary expansion of capitalism, as 'Eurocentric critics' rightfully pointed out, but was seen in essence also closely and complementarily connected to a specific epistemology as well as ways of knowing and being that sustained and stabilized a spatial articulation of power (in other words, coloniality), which in turn, silenced alternative epistemologies, ways of knowing and being. According to Walter Mignolo (2002: 59), the planetary expansion of Western capitalism thus also implied the expansion of Western epistemology (ibid.), and eventually of the social sciences; for this reason, this group of scholars called for the decolonization of the social sciences – rather than the 'opening' of the social sciences as the famous commission on the 'Restructuring of the Social Sciences' funded by the Calouste Gulbenkian Foundation advocated (Gulbenkian Commission, 1996). As Mignolo argued, an opening of the social sciences would simply maintain them as a planetary academic enterprise (2002: 64). In short, this strand of the debate focused on the role of knowledge – in particular, epistemologies that legitimated specific ways of knowing and being that privileged some groups over others and helped stabilize a (Western) spatial order. It is much in line with more recent discussions about 'Southern' or 'Mosaic' epistemologies (Connell, 2007, 2019) or arguments put forward for the

construction of a pluriverse (Escobar, 2018; Reiter, 2019) that aim at better balancing different (non-European) ontologies, epistemologies and methodologies, and thus countering hegemonial knowledge and spatial orders.

Against the background of the discussion above, the chapter argues that a *new* geopolitics of knowledge has emerged which entails the integration of knowledge production in HE in the strategic positioning of states, regions, and companies in global economic competitiveness circuits. In short, innovation, research capacity and education thus are reckoned key to succeeding in global economic competition. Higher education institutions have become key in the imaginations of knowledge-intensive capitalism and of how they are to contribute to innovation and economic growth, thus securing a safe place in the global economy. Higher education is invoked as the main *locus* of production both of (proprietary) knowledge (such as patents, innovations of all kinds, etc.), of innovative learning environments, and not least of human capital and associated subjectivities that will drive innovation (see also Moisiso & Kangas, 2016). In geopolitical terms, education and research are currently seen as *assets* that play a central role as generating both value and comparative advantages in the global competition, competitiveness and transnational value chains (see: Moisiso, 2018). It is worth noting that in this context, knowledge refers mainly to three things: (a) “to the role of ideas and related innovations in generating value in the production chain”; (b) to “the attempts to commodify knowledge [...]” including the processes of “knowledge-production by experts, professionals, academics and institutional actors” and (c) to “refer [...] to the ceaseless gathering of data on the development and performance of political communities as knowledge-based economies.” (Moisiso, 2018: 9) From the perspective of the second strand of the debate, the current transformations preserve and prolong the hegemony of a Western epistemology that is well aligned with knowledge-intensive capitalism; this has important consequences not only in geopolitical terms, but also impacts the internal logics of knowledge production: in that it favors specific epistemologies and methodologies; in that it gives preeminence to specific disciplinary fields; and not least in that it impacts the infrastructures for knowledge production and dissemination, or in other words, research and teaching in higher education.

In summing up, while in older debates, geopolitics of knowledge refers primarily to epistemological paradigms and philosophical projects of social/political hegemony, the contemporary discussions surrounding the ‘geopolitics of knowledge-based economy’ is conspicuously absorbed in discourses, governance technologies, calculative practices and subject formation that constitute a neoliberal assemblage called knowledge society or knowledge-based economy.

In referring to a *New Geopolitics of Knowledge* this chapter calls attention to the need to consider the politics of spatializing international politics of higher education, including the material and discursive practices deployed to do so. Here, the geopolitical perspective offers a prolific line of thought to examine how the integration of knowledge production and higher education in strategic imaginations and calculations of a host of actors is taking place currently. From this vantage point, we can scrutinize the implications for the insertion of HE in politico-economic projects and deliberate on the implications for the sector in general, and for academic

activities and scholarly work in particular. In terms of the latter, it seems crucial to take advantage of the insights from postcolonial criticism of the role of (social) science in stabilizing a colonial world order and question the impact of the changing knowledge regime (see: Parreira do Amaral, 2019). Moreover, beyond providing conceptual tools for a sound critique of hegemonic projects and related neoliberal assemblages, more recent work on the topic, for instance Arturo Escobar's ideas on 'Designs for the Pluriverse' invites us to deliberating on how pluriversal intellectual projects also offer useful ways to question and counter hegemonic imaginations, thus opening news avenues for thinking of possible alternatives. Indeed, it seems crucial to examine current developments and divest them of their pervasive 'there-is-no-alternative' rhetoric. The following section briefly discusses two contexts in which transforming higher education is seen as urgent and inevitable.

3.3 Transforming Higher Education: Redemption and Survival

This section discusses two sets of examples in which higher education has become central in political and economic imaginations of the future. *First*, a brief discussion of higher education and global regionalisms illustrates HE's embedding in politico-economic imaginations and strategies in Europe. *Second*, what has been coined a Global Education Industry (GEI) provides a fertile soil for economic rationales and initiatives to transform higher education worldwide. Seen together these two provide policy and ideational contexts for those interested in transforming HE.

Global Regionalisms refer to wide-ranging projects of regional political and economic integration of single states in different world blocs. Although regions may be viewed as phenomena at micro- or macro-levels, most conceptual work around regionalism centered upon world regions, emphasizing spatial-geographical relations and mutual interdependence among nation-states. With the intensification of globalization since the 1980s, the theme has been discussed in terms of contemporary changing world order with almost all 193 states taking part in one or the other regional project – for instance, the European Union (EU), the North American Free Trade Agreement (NAFTA), the Association of Southeast Asian Nations (ASEAN), the African Union (AU), the Caribbean Community (CARICOM), the Southern African Development Community (SADC), the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS), the Southern Common Market (Mercosur) or the Union of South American Nations (UNASUR).

Regionalism aims at creating – maintaining or modifying – the order of a world region by means of establishing a formal institution-building project or policy. It is stimulated by specific ideas, values and political, economic and social objectives as well as strategies that enrol and engage participant states in a common set of ideas and political and/or economic project. Briefly, while research on regionalism until

not very long ago mostly concentrated on economic and political integration,¹ more recent scholarship pays heed to geopolitical, cultural, and functional aspects and emphasize the multidimensional nature of the phenomena, including inter-regionalism as a pattern of interaction between world regional projects (cf. Söderbaum, 2016). Education, in particular, higher education, has only more recently become an object of study in global regionalism.

Scholarly work in the field of education drawing on literature on regionalism has at first focused on studying the impact of various regional organizations on education, mostly state-led organizations (see: Dale & Robertson, 2002). For instance, the argument was put forward that by exploring the different forms and purposes, the (hard or soft) dimensions of power, the (direct or indirect) nature of their effects, the processes and means of influence on the education system, as well as the scopes of international organizations it was possible to discern their varying social, political, and economic consequences for education. Robertson et al. (2016) have further developed this research perspective and promoted the development of a regionalism research strand, in particular, related to higher education. They pointed out to the constructedness of both the region(s) and of the higher education project(s) of international organizations such as the EU, MERCOSUR, ALBA, NAFTA or APEC by arguing:

that each of these organizations operates in a geographical ‘regional’ space that is itself constructed (for instance the ‘Asia Pacific’ or Latin America), that such regions are the deliberate creation of national governments ceding some authority and sovereignty to the bodies orchestrating and mediating their development, and that these global regionalisms differed from each other. These differences were not only the result of the kind of emphases they placed on the form of economic relations, but also because political, cultural and historical dynamics mediate the nature of their institutional forms and other social relations. (Robertson et al., 2016: 1)

This reconceptualization of research from simply analyzing the impact of the work of international/supranational organizations upon education to examining the role of education projects in imagining and constructing the world region itself, shifted attention to the role of higher education in the discursive construction of global regionalism proper, to new forms of inter-regionalism that hinted at global competition, and to the implications and impact for higher education, a sector in which much activity can be identified during the 20 years (Robertson et al., 2016). In short, global regionalism provides the context in which higher education became a central pillar of regional geopolitical imaginations, but also the policy contexts in which these ideas become reality. Research on the topic allows us to examine, various – and competing – projects, processes and, most interestingly, the politics of

¹See Haas (1958) for a founding text of the theme of regional integration from a functionalist perspective. In European Integration Studies, for instance, regionalism has been widely debated in terms of a new type of interstate cooperation that focused on integrative processes among interest groups, bureaucracies, and political parties. Regionalism meant here primarily a development that arose from endogenous forces as well as from “spillover” effects of economic integration that led to political unification (see also: Nye, 1968).

global regionalism projects in different continents (Robertson et al., 2016; Verger & Hermo, 2010; Jules, 2012, 2015; Tikly, 2017). Examples of examinations of regional projects in higher education are found, for instance, on four regional schemes in South America (Perrotta, 2016), on the Bolivarian Alliance for the People of Our America – People’s Trade Agreement (Alba-TCP) (Muhr, 2010), or on inter-regional policies between Asia and Europe (Robertson, 2008).

Elsewhere I have discussed the role and impact of the European regionalist project on education research (see: Parreira do Amaral, 2019). As discussed, most policies pertaining science, education and training have been crafted during the past 20 years in the aftermath of the EU Councils resolution to become the most competitive knowledge-based economy in the world. Very briefly, it was argued, education and research have been embedded in European economic imaginaries, such as the Europe 2020 or the Innovation Union strategies. In particular, implications for education research have become most visible in the current Horizon 2020 Research Framework Programme of the European Union. While previous research frameworks included an own funding scheme for Social Sciences and Humanities (SSHs), the new program stipulated that SSH research would be seen as cross-cutting and be integrated fully into the specific priorities and objectives of the frameworks for research and innovation of the Union – until recently called ‘societal challenges’, now termed ‘missions’ in the new Horizon Europe program beginning 2021 (see: EC, 2020). This integration of every program into Horizon 2020 has not only changed the previous disciplinary and thematic structure of funding schemes towards more focused resourcing of research that tackles strategic and technocratic interventions and instrumental solutions, but has also exacerbated hierarchical disciplinary divisions and created new tensions for SSH. This embedding of research into a framework oriented towards achieving geopolitical goals of the European Union affected not only its relationship to policy, but also has had important implications for epistemic governance as well as to the social epistemology of education (cf. Parreira do Amaral, 2019; see also: Normand, 2016).

A further context for current transformations of higher education relates to the emergence and expansion of what colleagues termed a *Global Education Industry* (GEI) in their attempting to understand the increasing (inter)penetration of education practice, provision, research and policy by economic rationales – economization, marketization, privatization, commodification, financialization (Verger et al., 2016; Parreira do Amaral et al., 2019; see also Thompson and Parreira do Amaral, 2019). Verger et al. (2016: 3) pointed out to a “new [...] conception of education as a sector that is increasingly globalized and managed by private organizations.” Scholarship on the GEI offered a re-reading (see: Simons et al., 2009) of the globalization of education which for them has taken on a different meaning, and pointed to a new facet of this development: education has become an economic enterprise unto itself, in which myriad actors produce, exchange, and consume educational goods and services, often on a for-profit basis (Verger et al., 2016: 4). As a context for those involved in imagining and re-imagining, reforming, and transforming (higher) education the GEI presents itself as “constituted by its own sets of

processes, systems of rules, and social forces, which interact in the production, offer and demand of educational services and goods.” (ibid.)

Research on the GEI has so far focused on unveiling and understanding these processes and forces, theorizing thus the complexity, different manifestations and functionings (Verger et al., 2016); further, attempts have also been made to examine the rationales and logics of action as well as the modes of operation of the players, allowing for an assessment of the increasing impact that comes from these platforms, coalitions, and connections of very different actors (see: Parreira do Amaral & Thompson, 2019). In short, the GEI illustrates the rationales, interest and processes involved in constructing and fostering educational imaginaries of innovation and modernization that call for the substitution or disruption of education systems as we know them. The GEI may be seen as a central feature of the global dimension of education at present, consisting of mutual rationales, logics and modes of operation, but, more critically, of concepts built on prevailingly economic footings that have come to permeate education reform and restructuring across the globe.

Both the integration of higher education in global regionalisms and the expansion of a global education industry provided both theoretical, policy and ideational paradigms (see: Jessop, 2008) for current imaginations and constructions of higher education that potentially will lead to a substantial transformation of the field. In linking the previous discussion to the geopolitical perspective suggested for the examination of the transformations of higher education, the following section briefly presents and discusses two projects to reshape and disrupt higher education before a discussion of the implications of these developments for the field rounds out the chapter.

3.4 (Re-)Imagining and (Re-)constructing Higher Education

This section presents and discusses two distinct examples of how higher education has been inserted in the geopolitical imaginations of world regions/states and of business actors. The argument is that a geopolitical perspective provides productive and insightful lenses to better understand the (re)imagining and (re-)constructing higher education.

3.4.1 International Higher Education Hubs

The term International Education Hubs (IEHs) was coined amidst debates about novel forms of internationalization of higher education; indeed, IEHs are seen by some as “the latest development [...] represent[ing] a wider and more strategic configuration of actors and activities, building on and including many of the recent developments in cross-border higher education (Knight, 2014a: 84). A predominant form of IEH, is a “country-level hub where a country is building and positioning

itself as an attractive and acknowledged center of education, training, knowledge production, and innovation activities.” (Knight, 2014b: 5) From a geopolitical perspective, the latter may be taken to refer to different types of politico-economic projects attempting to more closely link higher education systems to economic demands for achieving structural competitiveness and increasing innovation for the knowledge-based economy (see also the chapter by Erfurth, in this volume).

Different models of IEHs have been identified in the literature – student, talent, or knowledge/innovation hubs (see: Knight, 2014c) – that characterize different approaches and strategies in shaping higher education. *Student hubs* refer to projects aiming to “widen access to higher education students, modernize and internationalize domestic HEIs, raise the profile of the country’s higher education system, and generate revenue from the influx of foreign students” (Knight & Lee, 2014: 31). A *talent hub* purports to “expand the pool of skilled workers, contribute to a service and/or knowledge economy, increase economic competitiveness, and improve the quality and relevance of the labor force” (ibid.: 32). A *knowledge/innovation hub* “focuses on the production and application of new knowledge which has the potential for commercial use [...]” and goes well beyond higher education to incorporate “research conducted by public and private partnerships and the corporate sector.” (ibid.: 33f.) Several IEHs were created during the past years, located predominantly in East-Asia and the Middle-East, with the intention to become global preferred destinations for higher learning and research capacity, for instance: Hong Kong (Mok & Bodycott, 2014), United Arab Emirates (Halsey Fox & Al Shamisi, 2014; Erfurth, 2019), Singapore (Shidu et al., 2014; Erfurth, 2019).

Well beyond representing plain internationalization strategies, IEHs are better understood as geopolitical projects that signal a rearrangement of the relationships between state, economy, society, and higher education within selected territories (and beyond), linking higher education development and governance to global competition. Moreover, as Erfurth argued, IEHs exemplify the changing role of the state itself: a shift from state’s monopoly role in sponsoring/providing education to an extension and strengthening of its regulation role as a power connector (see: Erfurth, 2019). Indeed, as part of a large-scale politico-economic projects, the organization of higher education becomes enmeshed in global interconnections of competition, cooperation, and conflict, with implications for higher education policy and governance. Attending to this link to global competition is important because the rationales for governing higher education is arguably shifting from social or educational categories (such as accessibility, affordability, equity, quality, mobility, open research, progress, and so forth) to economic categories such as revenue generation, the production of patentable, non-open research and knowledge as well as economic competitiveness.

Examining IEHs from a geopolitical perspective helps us understand how the different levels – local to global – are interrelated to each other and constitute global discursive spaces, but also spatialize (economic) goals of specific states/actors in terms of their participation and position in the global knowledge economy.

3.4.2 *Constructing the Intentional University: The Minerva Project*

The second example is a recent start-up from California that has proposed to disrupt higher education, creating a new institutional setup from scratch. The Minerva Project is a for-profit elite online university founded by businessman and former CEO of Snapfish Ben Nelson. The ambition has been high from the outset, namely to create „the most selective university program in American history“ (Nelson, 2018: xviv) that would serve as a model for other institutions across the globe by being undisputed in excellence and providing a higher education experience that others cannot provide, not even Harvard, Cambridge, Oxford or other elite institutions. The Minerva Project was born in September 2010 in San Francisco, USA, and impresses with the speed with which it has developed into an accredited, operating higher education institution. Only little more than 4 years passed before venture funding of 25 million US\$ was obtained from Benchmark Capital, or as Nelson puts it „the most respected investment firm of the time“ in Silicon Valley (Nelson, 2018: xxi), the first employee hired, the first pilot group of students launched and the first official students in four-year study programs started. This swift pace of development is comprehensible once one considers the vast network of highly influential people involved in the venture – politicians, former university presidents, renowned academics, marketing and public relations experts and entrepreneurs (see: Nelson, 2018 for an overview).

Partnered with a member of The Claremont Colleges,² the Keck Graduate Institute, Minerva draws on shared, available institutional infrastructure to build an efficient and scalable business and operating model. It has no campus, no faculty buildings, no class- or lecture rooms, no amenities such as athletics or other sports facilities. All classes are conducted online via digital technology developed for the Project.

The Minerva Project departs from two basic ideas that offer justification for radically changing higher education. In the words of Chief Academic Officer, Stephen Kosslyn, and Minerva's CEO, Ben Nelson: First „we are facing a dire, cross-sector, global shortage of effective leaders [...and second] education, and specifically higher education, must play a critical role in solving this problem“ (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018a: 5). The goal of the project is to reinvent higher education and „give students the cognitive tools they would need to succeed after they graduated“ (ibid.: 1) as well as getting to leading positions in a changing, globalized world. Among these cognitive tools are „four core competencies: critical thinking, creative thinking, effective communication, and effective interactions“ (ibid.: 9) around

²The Claremont Colleges is a consortium of highly selective private institutions founded by Congregationalists in Pomona, California in 1925 and was inspired by the Oxford University model. The consortium provides both students and the member institutions with administrative and operational services and coordination with the aim of cutting costs by offering shared services. See: <https://services.claremont.edu/> [last Jan. 4, 2021].

which the curricula and programs are built based on a science of learning pedagogy and digital technology (see: Fost et al., 2018).

The Project identifies and proposes solutions to four common problems facing higher education: relevance, costs, efficiency, and access.

- *Relevance*, the common diagnosis is that despite completing their studies graduates are not prepared for life. To tackle this problem the programs focus on so-called *practical knowledge*, with the aim of equipping „students with intellectual tools they can use to adapt to a changing world and achieve their goals“ (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018a: 7). The proposition is not to train students for a specific job, so that they are also able to be successful at previously nonexistent jobs. Further, „an international hybrid residential model whereby students take classes on their computer but live together, rotating through different cities around the world“ (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018a: 8) is deemed to put students in touch with different cultures and be prepared to cope with and work in different societal contexts.
- *High costs*, the issue of too high tuition fees is tackled by radically reducing costs of large infrastructures construction, maintenance and administration. In general, most of staff are left out, there are no academic departments and therefore no secretaries, departments heads and staff, etc. The undergraduate tuition for the academic year 2020–2021 is \$14,450.00 and the total estimated costs for the year is \$27,950.00 (\$31,900 fourth year only), plus around \$5000.00 for living; this amounts to approximately one third of regular top-tier US universities, as they argue. Despite this, there are less than 20 students per class, and student services are still provided such as experiential learning programs, orientation, mental health support, residential services, and a living allowance (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018a: 7; see also Minerva, 2020a).
- *Efficiency*, dropout rates/grade inflation are seen as the main issues in delivering education effectively. Here, the Project’s answer is to design a program based on findings of science of learning, and to give personalized attention by means of close monitoring, a so-called „full active learning [... and a] radically flipped classroom“ (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018a: 11, emphasis in original). It means that all lectures and homework are done at home, with the possibility of support by other students and the teacher, in class. Further, there is a self-developed cloud-based program, called the Active Learning Forum (ALF), which contained special tools, „such as polls, voting, collaborative editing, and the ability quickly to compose breakout groups in various ways“ (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018a: 12) and is also used to monitor and collect data of individual development.
- *Access*, the main issue is that, globally, most qualified students cannot afford accessing a high-quality institution. Here, Minerva proposes to accept all qualified students without balancing admission based on any ethnic, gender or other demographic category. Students unable to pay for the tuition fees “receive a combination of work-study, modest loans, and grants.” (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018a: 8).

The reimagining of higher education illustrated by Minerva is pervasive and radical – as the proponents argue, they “push the reset button on higher education” with

the aim of ‘solving the world’s problems’. It sees itself as acting ‘for the sake of the world’ (Nelson et al., 2018: 377) and purports to offer a ‘meta-recipe book’ with a “systemic logic, first-principles-driven institutional design, and uncompromising iterative process with which new models of education can be built.” (ibid.) Against the background of this high ambition, it appears as no coincidence that the Project’s eponym is not only known as the Roman goddess of wisdom and tutelary goddess of poets and teachers, but also that of tactical warfare.³ In terms of discursive practice, the publication of a book branding the project comes close to a missionary commitment to reshape the future of higher education (Kosslyn & Nelson, 2018b).

Although the operating range of the Minerva Project is still small and expansion appears rather restricted so far, due to several factors (not least international mobility in times of global pandemics) the main potential impact of this venture is its providing of not only a disruptive imagination of the future of HE but also an institutional setup and thought-out design that is viewed by many as a necessary innovation – in particular its ‘radically flipped classroom’ and digital technology with the promise of both cost reduction *and* high-quality/efficiency. A geopolitical perspective also allows us to deliberate on the spatialization of the project, which while located in the United States, aims at catering to ‘the world’, thus presenting itself as placeless and at the same time linking different global cities (San Francisco, Buenos Aires, Berlin, London, Hyderabad, Seoul and Taipei) in their global immersion feature in-built in the curriculum (Minerva, 2020b).

The two examples discussed in this section, although taken from distinct places and focusing quite different developments, hint at the pervasiveness of the geopolitical transformations that higher education is undergoing. They show how different actors – states, for-profit companies, individuals – are actively reimagining higher education, both in terms of their relations to other sectors of society and the functions it is to fulfil, but also in terms of the forms of organization, curricular formats, and social relations. While the first example, the international hubs, remain closely related to the territorial – and power – dimension of their promoters, the second, Minerva, ventures more clearly into the placeless flows and hubs of the New geopolitics of knowledge.

3.5 Conclusion

This chapter set out to suggest that a geopolitical perspective is useful in better understanding ongoing transformations in higher education globally. It has presented and discussed two strands of research that debate the theme of a geopolitics of knowledge; *first*, a recent discussion of the geopolitics of the knowledge-based economization that draws from intellectual developments in the disciplines of

³Minerva also adorns the Great Seal of California. The reference here is not only to the goddess of wisdom and knowledge, but also a reference that California was never a territory before becoming a state, an allusion to Minerva as she was born an adult from Jupiter’s body (see: Apel, 2020).

geography; *second*, a debate sprung out of postcolonial criticism of the role of knowledge and epistemology in world order. Taken together, this perspective was drawn upon to argue that a *New Geopolitics of Knowledge* has emerged, in which currently higher education is integrated in the strategic imaginations and calculations of a host of actors – from global regions, states, to companies.

Central to the discussion is promoting an understanding of its functions as an imaginary of a preferred future that produces specific narratives and sustain particular policy paradigms as well as institutional designs that are in line with global knowledge-intensive capitalism. The discussion of geopolitics of knowledge in the preceding sections point to how HE and research are – on the one hand – seen as *assets* that play a central role as generating both value and comparative advantages in the (imageries of) global competition, competitiveness and transnational value chains, promising thus a comparative advantage in their asserting and/or improving their position in the global economy. They are integrated in the struggles for – economic, social, cultural – dominance of states and their ruling strata. Further, the two lines of the debate discussed above also show how knowledge production in higher education is part and parcel of the world order and the attempts to challenge, change or maintain a status quo that is no less pernicious than the old age colonial system. Notwithstanding the rhetorics of global unhindered (knowledge) exchange and international mobility, the current geopolitical transformations that higher education is undergoing, preserve and prolong what Mignolo and others have critiqued already in the mid-1990s.

Against this background, the New Geopolitics of Knowledge impacts substantially on higher education. Knowledge-intensive capitalism not only favors specific (positivist, empiricist) epistemologies and methodologies, it also gives preference to specific disciplinary fields and types of knowledge. Taken together, they bear importance for the infrastructures for knowledge production and dissemination, or in other words, research, teaching and learning in higher education.

From the perspective of Comparative and International (Higher) Education, this phenomenon is a matter of concern because it illustrates the increasing complexity in higher education policy, which potentially produces unforeseen, disruptive effects through the interplay of the ‘global’ and ‘local’, the discursive and the material. In the context of global education research, a geopolitical perspective provides an opportunity to study the intricate relations that constitute global discursive spaces, while at the same time attending to the interests and power play of global regionalisms, nation-states and companies competing for a place in the sun of the global knowledge-based economy. A reason for concern pertains not only the changed relationships of higher education to society, state, and the economy; it also raises questions about the far-reaching consequences and profound implications for higher education teaching and research infrastructures, policy and governance. Further, the geopolitical lens suggested here supports us in raising questions as to the geopolitical imaginations and the implications for the role and validations of science and education; the implications of these for social science and education research in terms of epistemology or epistemic governance; the learning environments as well as sites and modes of knowledge production; the archetypal subjectivities that are to

be produced – innovative, entrepreneurial, connected – and the deployed governmental technologies; and not least, the implications of these developments for individuals in general and for academic careers in particular, including their impact on working conditions on academic personnel.

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